Model Answers — Calibration Pack for ABCC 2027 Practice

For the HSBI team and coach | July 2026

This pack contains two worked models: a complete answer outline for re-cracking the **Access Credit Union 2026 traditional case**, and a filled **one-page judge brief** for the **AROW Global 2025 boardroom case**. Both are built to the official ABCC format and the 2025 Event Guide rubric, in which **Implementation & Resources carries a 2.5x weight** — the single heaviest category — followed by Analysis (2.0x) and Recommendation (2.0x). Everything marked *(illustrative)* is a planning placeholder showing the *shape and precision level* judges expect; in a live crack you must rebuild those numbers from the case appendices and your own research (internet and generative AI are permitted during prep).

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1. Worked model answer outline — Access Credit Union (2026 Traditional Case, re-crack)

Case: *"Access Credit Union: Designing Digital Banking"* — advise Manitoba's largest credit union (~$14.1B assets, 208,000+ members, 925+ employees, ~50 branches) on service innovations and digital banking to engage young people — Gen Z and Gen Alpha — and reverse youth attrition.

Re-crack conditions (match the real round): 3-hour prep, no coach or outside contact after release, one laptop per student, internet and GenAI allowed, prebuilt own template permitted. Deliver a 20-minute presentation plus 10-minute Q&A (yellow card at 5 minutes remaining, red at 1 — in both periods); every team member must speak; deck saved to USB as "[Team Name] Traditional Case". Present as your fictional consulting firm — never identify HSBI (identifying your school to a judge means disqualification).

The storyline in one sentence

Access cannot out-app the Big 5 or out-yield Wealthsimple, but it owns the one asset no fintech can copy — members own the institution — so the winning move is to turn ownership into a product young Manitobans can feel, delivered through a digital front door and a life-stage ladder, funded in part by the savings from branch consolidation.

Action-title storyline (18 slides — the titles alone must carry the argument)

1. Access can win the next generation — or watch it bank elsewhere: a decision for today
2. Manitoba's largest credit union is strong on paper — and aging in fact
3. Youth attrition is a slow leak that compounds: fewer first accounts today mean fewer mortgages tomorrow
4. Young Manitobans are not rejecting Access — most were never offered a front door
5. Three segments matter most: rural farm-succession teens, urban students, and first-paycheque Gen Z
6. Their jobs-to-be-done are simple: open instantly, pay no fees, build credit, belong to something real
7. Fintechs win on speed and polish — but they cannot offer ownership; Access can
8. Recommendation: "Own It" — make membership a product young people can feel, through three moves
9. Move 1 — Open the front door: ten-minute mobile onboarding and a no-fee youth account
10. Move 2 — Make ownership visible: an annual youth dividend and a genuine member voice
11. Move 3 — Build the ladder: first paycheque to first credit card to first mortgage or farm loan
12. Rural is the beachhead, not the burden: schools and member families are a trusted channel no fintech has
13. The prize *(illustrative)*: 12,000 new members under 30 for roughly $8M, with cohort payback inside six years
14. Implementation: 36 months, four phases, named owners, and a go/no-go gate before each dollar escalates
15. The first 200 days: a five-community pilot proves acquisition cost and activation before provincial launch
16. We will measure the ladder, not app downloads: activation, retention, and products per member
17. The risks are real, priced, and gated — the unpriced risk is another decade of drift
18. The ask: approve Phase 0–1 funding today; the pilot reports back with evidence in nine months

The recommendation, with illustrative quantification

Recommendation (slide 8): Launch **"Own It"**, a youth membership platform for Manitobans aged 14–30, built on three moves — (1) instant digital onboarding into a no-fee youth account, (2) a visible annual ownership dividend plus a youth advisory council, and (3) a designed life-stage ladder from first deposit to first credit product to mortgage, agricultural loan, or wealth account (leveraging the existing Credential/Qtrade/Aviso wealth capability).

Targets and economics — all figures illustrative, to be rebuilt from case appendices:

Metric	Illustrative figure	Logic shown to judges
Members under 30 today	~31,000 (assume ~15% of 208,000)	Stated as a planning assumption, sanity-checked against the case exhibit. The quant drill in `04-training/exercises/workbook2_quant_drills.md` §2.2c runs the same base at a more conservative 11% (~22,900) — either is defensible, but say which one you took, and note that at 11% the +12,000 target is ~+52% of the youth segment, not ~+40%
Acquisition target	**+12,000 net new members aged 14–30 in 36 months** (~4,000/yr)	≈ +6% total membership; ≈ +40% growth of the youth segment; a niche share of Manitoba's youth cohort — we do not need to "beat" Wealthsimple
Investment	**~$8.0M over 3 years**: Yr 1 $4.5M (platform build $2.5M, operations $1.0M, marketing $1.0M); Yrs 2–3 $1.75M each	Partially funded by redeploying savings from the six announced branch consolidations
All-in cost per acquired member	~$670 (marketing-only ~$210)	Framed against retail-banking acquisition benchmarks researched during prep
Member contribution	~$60–90/yr early relationship → ~$250–400/yr with first credit product → $700+/yr at mortgage/ag-loan stage	The ladder is the business case, not the youth account itself
Payback	**Cohort payback in year 5–6** at 55–60% five-year retention; retained members reaching the lending stage carry an estimated lifetime NPV of $3,000–5,000 → program option value $18–30M against $8M spent	Long horizon stated honestly — this is a lifetime-value business, and the aging book makes waiting more expensive each year

Implementation roadmap — the 2.5x slide (slide 14, supported by 15)

This slide must answer the rubric question directly: *a clear path to follow, with resources, time, and financial considerations.* Model content:

Governance: Executive sponsor: Chief Marketing/Member Officer. Accountable owner: a newly named **GM, Youth Segment**. Core squad of 8–10 FTE (product lead, digital/IT, marketing, compliance, data analyst, one branch lead per region) plus an onboarding/KYC technology vendor. Quarterly board dashboard.

Phase	Timing	What happens	Resources & cost *(illustrative)*	Go/no-go gate
0 — Mobilize	Months 0–3	Name GM and squad; select KYC/onboarding vendor (fixed-scope MVP contract); design custodial account with parental consent for minors and pre-engage the regulator; baseline metrics	Squad stood up; ~$0.8M	Vendor signed; compliant minor-account design approved
1 — Pilot	Months 3–9	Instant onboarding + no-fee youth account live in 3 rural communities and 2 Winnipeg campuses; 25 school and member-family partnerships; target 1,500 members	~$1.7M	30-day activation ≥ 60%; marketing CAC ≤ $350; youth NPS positive
2 — Provincial launch	Months 9–18	Full launch; ownership dividend v1 paid visibly in-app; gamified saving and financial-literacy content; youth advisory council seated; cumulative 6,000 members	~$2.75M	Cumulative members ≥ 5,000; cost per member on model; dormancy < 25%
3 — Ladder	Months 18–36	First-credit builder card; ag-succession program with the wealth team; family bundles; embed in business-as-usual	~$2.75M	≥ 20% of 24-month cohort holds 2+ products; cohort economics tracking to payback

First 200 days (slide 15): week-by-week pilot plan — vendor build sprint, school MOUs signed by month 4, first live account by month 5, mid-pilot CAC read at month 7, gate decision with evidence pack at month 9. The board never commits more than one phase of spend at a time.

KPIs (slide 16): net new members under 30; 30-day activation (first deposit plus three transactions); monthly active users; products per member at 24 months; cohort retention; CAC by channel; youth NPS; share of local student market.

Risk table (slide 17)

Risk	Likelihood / impact	Mitigation	Early indicator
Accounts opened but dormant	Med / High	Activation-first design (direct-deposit incentive, streaks); Gate 1 kill-switch	30-day activation < 60% in pilot
CAC overruns	Med / Med	Weight school and member-family referral channels; cap paid media; referral engine	Pilot CAC > $350
Rural backlash — "apps while branches close"	Med / High	Frame consolidation savings as reinvestment; town halls; video advice and service standards for consolidated communities	Member-satisfaction dip in affected towns
Compliance/KYC for minors (Gen Alpha)	Med / Med	Custodial design with parental consent; regulator pre-engagement in Phase 0	Approval slippage past month 3
Competitor response (Big-5 promos, Wealthsimple, or a fellow Manitoba credit union copying)	High / Med	Differentiate on ownership dividend and local lending ladder — hard to copy; move fast	Competitor youth-offer launches
Execution capacity / vendor delay	Med / Med	Fixed-scope MVP, contractual penalties, phased gates	Sprint slippage > 4 weeks

Six anticipated judge questions — with model answers

1. "Why would a 19-year-old choose Access over Wealthsimple?" We do not ask them to choose against Wealthsimple on yield or interface — those are table stakes we must simply meet. We win where fintechs cannot follow: a real ownership dividend, a local lending ladder (first car loan, mortgage, farm succession), and the gravity of 208,000 member households, many of them these young people's parents. And our target is modest by design — 12,000 members over three years is a niche share of Manitoba's youth, not a national land-grab.

2. "Your payback is five to six years. Why should a board accept that?" Because member banking is a lifetime-value business, and the alternative compounds against us: every year of an aging book means fewer future mortgages and ag loans. Three protections make the horizon acceptable: the program is partly funded from consolidation savings rather than new money; the board only ever approves one phase at a time behind evidence gates; and the pilot tests the two assumptions that drive payback — CAC and activation — before 80% of the spend is committed.

3. "You are closing rural branches and building an app. How is that co-operative?" The consolidations were driven by falling in-branch traffic and rising mobile adoption — that trend exists whether or not we act. Our program is the reinvestment story that makes it defensible: the savings help fund the next generation of members, and rural youth get *more* access than today — school partnerships, custodial accounts through their families, and video advice — not less. We would say exactly that, publicly, in the affected communities.

4. "What if your acquisition cost doubles?" At double the marketing CAC (~$420), cohort payback extends by roughly 18 months but the program remains NPV-positive at midpoint lifetime values *(illustrative sensitivity shown in appendix)*. More importantly, we learn the true CAC in a $1.7M pilot, not a full launch — and our first levers are channel-mix shifts toward referrals and schools, which are cheap, before we ever raise paid spend.

5. "Why build this rather than partner with a fintech?" Hybrid, deliberately: we buy commodity rails — onboarding and KYC from a proven vendor — for speed, and build only the differentiating layer: the ownership dividend, the ladder, the community channel. A pure white-label would make Access a commodity skin on someone else's product; Access already shows partnering discipline in wealth (Credential/Qtrade/Aviso), and we follow that pattern.

6. "Gen Alpha are children. How do you actually reach them?" Through the two channels that already trust us: member families and schools. Custodial accounts with parental consent turn our existing membership into the distribution network; financial-literacy programs and gamified saving make the account useful before it is profitable. Gen Alpha is the pipeline and Gen Z the near-term revenue — compliance for minors is designed in Phase 0, not bolted on.

Speaker split (every member must speak): a natural four-way split is slides 1–7 (framing and analysis), 8–13 (recommendation and economics), 14–16 (implementation and measurement — give this to a strong finisher; it is the 2.5x territory), and 17–18 plus Q&A leadership (risks and the ask).

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2. Sample one-page judge brief — AROW Global (2025 Boardroom Case)

Case: *"AROW Global: Looking for the Next Big Idea"* — the 1965-founded Winnipeg manufacturer of transit-bus window systems and driver protection systems (~530 employees; plants in Winnipeg and Mosinee, Wisconsin, plus the Techni-Glass factory in Tennessee; ~90% share in configurable DPS) asks for its next product/market: **≥$10M annual revenue** (ideally a $30–40M market), **40% margin, cash-flow positive within 3 years, $4–5M year-one investment**; blue-ocean B2B, truck/rail-shippable; no smart glass, no bus shelters, nothing structurally complex.

Why this artifact matters: in the boardroom round, judges receive your one-page **black-and-white** executive brief in advance of your entrance, you then get a protected 3 minutes on a single summary slide, and the remaining 22 minutes are discussion. The brief is your opening argument delivered before you say a word — it must survive greyscale printing, a 90-second skim, and hostile margin notes. Numbers below are illustrative model-answer figures.

TEAM C — MERIDIAN ADVISORY | *Executive Brief for the Board of AROW Global | Boardroom Case*

RECOMMENDATION

Enter operator-protection and cab-glazing systems for agricultural and construction equipment ("FieldGuard") — targeting $12M annual revenue at 42% gross margin by Year 3 on a $4.2M Year-1 investment — committed in three evidence gates, not one leap.

Off-highway cabs need what AROW already builds for buses: certified glazing, operator protection, and configurable window assemblies — sold B2B, shipped by truck, structurally simple, and outside our stated no-go zones.

PILLAR 1 — The market clears every screen (illustrative)

- *Serviceable North American niche: **$30–40M** (OEM cab glazing plus a fragmented retrofit/aftermarket for ag and construction fleets) — inside the target band, above the $10M revenue floor.*
- *Fragmented supply, no configurable-systems specialist: **blue ocean** relative to Ricon/Wabtec's transit focus; Lippert not yet present in this niche.*
- *Demand drivers: operator-safety regulation, equipment lifespans lengthening (retrofit), dealer networks seeking one certified source.*

PILLAR 2 — Capability transfer above 80%

- *Reuses existing glass processing (Techni-Glass), aluminum extrusion, stamping, welding, and assembly across Winnipeg and Mosinee — **no new plant**.*
- *Configurable-DPS engineering (90% share in transit) is the transferable edge: cab-by-cab configuration at production cost.*
- *To acquire: 2 off-highway sales hires, ag/construction certification testing, dealer-channel agreements — bought, not built.*

PILLAR 3 — Staged validation caps the downside

- ***Gate 1 (Months 0–6, $0.6M):** 20 structured customer interviews; 2 OEM/dealer LOIs; certification scoping.* Kill if no LOI.

- ***Gate 2 (Months 6–15, $1.6M):*** *prototypes on 3 pilot fleets; certification passed; signed first orders ≥ $0.75M.* Kill if pilots miss spec.
- ***Gate 3 (Months 15–24, $2.0M):*** *production cell fitted into Mosinee; dealer channel live in 2 regions.*

FINANCIALS **(illustrative)**

	Yr 1	*Yr 2*	*Yr 3*
Revenue	*$1.5M*	*$6.0M*	***$12.0M***
Gross margin	*35%*	*40%*	***42%***
Investment	*$4.2M*	*$0.8M*	—
Cash flow	*–$3.4M*	*–$0.4M*	***positive (Q3)***

Meets the mandate: ≥$10M revenue, ≥40% margin, cash-flow positive within 3 years, Year-1 investment inside $4–5M.

TOP RISKS AND MITIGATIONS

1. ***Demand thinner than sized*** *→ Gate 1 LOIs before 85% of spend; retrofit and OEM are two independent demand legs.*
2. ***Certification delay*** *→ scoped in Gate 1 with external test lab; buffer in Gate 2 timeline.*
3. ***Incumbent price response*** *→ compete on configurability and certified one-source supply, not price; transit relationships (New Flyer/NFI, BC Transit) unaffected.*
4. ***Capacity conflict with core DPS line*** *→ dedicated cell, hired-not-diverted staffing.*

THE ASK — NEXT 90 DAYS

Approve ***$0.6M Gate-1 funding*** *and name an internal FieldGuard lead; Meridian returns to this board at Day 90 with LOIs and a certified go/no-go recommendation.*

Why this brief works (use as a checklist): the recommendation is one bolded sentence a judge can repeat; every case constraint is answered *visibly*, in the client's own numbers; three pillars each carry data, not adjectives; the financial table proves the screen line by line; risks are paired with mitigations the team chose in advance (so the 22-minute grilling lands on prepared ground); and the ask is small, dated, and reversible. It is entirely legible in black-and-white — no colour coding, no charts that die in greyscale.

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3. How to use these models

These are **calibration instruments, not scripts**. Their job is to show the standard: what an action-title storyline sounds like when the titles alone carry the argument, what "quantified" means (a labelled, assumption-visible number, not false precision), how heavy the implementation slide must be to earn its 2.5x weight, and how a one-pager argues before you enter the room. Do not memorise the Access answer and replay it — the 2027 cases will be different Manitoba organizations, and judges reward reasoning built from *that case's* appendices in *that day's* three or four hours. After each timed re-crack, hold your own output against these models and score the gaps: Were our titles a storyline? Was every big number sourced or labelled? Did our roadmap name owners, costs, and gates? Did we pre-write the judges' six hardest questions? Close those gaps, then re-crack the next case. When your team's cold output matches this standard under time pressure, the models have done their work — and you should be arguing with them, not copying them.